

ALL AFLUTTER *RRR* flags on the Ganga during the film's promotion in Varanasi

availed of the subsidies, claims Navneet Sehgal, additional chief secretary, MSME, khadi, information & PR and Film Bandhu. "The combination of Kashi, the holy city; Ganga the holy river; and Lord Shiva, the Supreme God, makes Varanasi an immortal destination," says the Film Bandhu website in its entry for the city.

Sehgal attributes filmdom's fixation with Varanasi to the city being "*Shiv ki nagari*" as well as Prime Minister Narendra Modi's constituency. "Infrastructure in the city has improved a lot in the past seven years," he says. The Kashi-Vishwanath corridor project has led to more tourist footfalls. Almost 20 ghats conduct Ganga *aarti* now and VIP *aarti darshans* are a common sight. More flights between Mumbai and Varanasi have eased connectivity. Requests to shoot by the *ghats*—Rajendra Prasad, Dashashwamedh, Chet Singh and Assi are sought after—and near the Kashi Vishwanath temple have soared.

Among the individuals who field many of these shoot requests is theatre artist and actor Rati Shankar Tripathi. Apart from acting in films like *Gangs of Wasseypur* and *Super 30*, Tripathi works as a line producer, and recently managed promotions of *Samrat Prithviraj* and *RRR*. Varanasi is beloved for its old *mohalla*s, he says. Due to an uptick in shoots, including for the popular web series *Mirzapur*, and promotions, Tripathi is happy that UP's theatre artists are getting a lot more jobs. Varanasi's presence on social media has also surged with Instagram reels of star sightings across the city.



"VARANASI HAS A HOLD OVER THE COLLECTIVE SUBCONSCIOUS OF THE COUNTRY.... WHAT HAPPENS HERE RESONATES THROUGHOUT INDIA"

PRABHAT CHOUDHARY, *Founder, Spice PR*

Gaurav Kapoor, who runs an event management company and also organises premium tours in Varanasi, says there's been more interest in the city since 2017 after the Modi government was re-elected. "Bollywood knows that in Modi's India, if you come to Modi's Varanasi and tweet a photo, the traction you get would be more than anywhere else in UP," he says. "In Lucknow, the normal thing to do while promoting a film would be eating kebabs, which probably is a no-no in the new India." Kapoor feels that it's all part of the need for a "subtle reaffirmation" of one's Hindu identity.

Prabhat Choudhary, though, feels Varanasi's appeal goes beyond religion. Its rich legacy in literature, music and handicrafts also makes it an artistic paradise. With Spice, he intends to regularly feature Varanasi in promotional itineraries. "But the idea would be to do something different each time we visit the place," he says. "Believe me, there are infinite mysteries in Kashi and it enjoys an unparalleled connect with the common man in India." In Varanasi, Bollywood has faith. ■